HARDIK CHHABRA



ALAKH PANDEY, 30
Prayagraj, Uttar Pradesh

Company	Net Worth
PhysicsWallah	**Rs 4,000 crore**

COVER STORY
BUSINESS

BEST IN CLASS

Financial necessity first forced him to work as a tutor, but teaching finally became a calling for Alakh Pandey. So much so that he quit his engineering course at the Harcourt Butler Technical Institute in Kanpur, becoming "a 50 per cent mechanical engineer". His background in theatre in school made his physics lessons like no other. Impressed by his style of teaching, his mentor and employer Amir Farooqui predicted he'd teach 7,000 students one day. The thought stuck.

YouTube became the answer to his quest to reach more students. Pandey created his own channel in 2015, calling it 'PhysicsWallah Alakh'. A Facebook page followed. But response remained limited, despite Pandey posting science memes and quizzes and offering 'mobile recharge of Rs 50 to the right answerer of the quiz'.

The advent of cheap 4G services in 2017 proved to be a blessing. He began teaching Class 10 students. His subscribers increased to 10,000 and YouTube gave him his first cheque of Rs 8,000 in 2018 when he hit 50,000 subscribers.

Pandey continued free classes on YouTube till 2020. When Covid hit in March that year and new possibilities opened up for edu-tech, Pandey found a new partner in Prateek Maheshwari who designed an app for him. Unlike his rivals, Pandey offered courses at Rs 2,000–3,000 per subject. Over 60,000 students enrolled for the first online batch. There has been no looking back.

-Vinay Sultan

75 countries. In Thiruvananthapuram, V.K. Mathews of IBS Software, acquired seven global companies in 25 years to become a leading name in providing travel solutions. Bhubaneswar's Tara Ranjan Patnaik went against the tide to explore a future in marine exports. The Virani brothers of Rajkot, Gujarat, made a success out of setting up large distribution networks to reach customers faster—their company Balaji Wafers covers 40 per cent of the country. Yet others made a leap of faith and invested in the latest technology, aided by small loans from banks. Subhas Kamath of Udupi's Abharan Jewellers says he was the first in India to import a gold testing machine to ensure the purity of the metal, convincing customers of the quality of the gold he sold.

Many have taken advantage of supportive state and central policies. In recent years, several states have been vying with each other to attract more investment, holding large business fairs, taking out roadshows in other states and overseas to showcase investment